

COM 1130: INTERVIEWING



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COM 1130: Interviewing

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Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: Overview of Interviewing

Learning Objectives

After reading this chapter, you should be able to:

- Understand the importance of interviewing and its applicability to a variety of careers
- Identify the types of interviews we will focus on in this course
- Understand the principles of ethical communication and how they connect to interviewing

[1.1: Why Study Interviewing?](#)

[1.2: Interview Types](#)

[1.3: Ethical Interviewing](#)

[1.4: Resources](#)

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1.1: Why Study Interviewing?

We are participating in interviews every day. That may sound surprising but at its essence, interviewing is simply the process of seeking or providing information. Interviewing is one of the most important and practical skills students can learn and develop. Interviewing will be your bread and butter as a communicator. It is the means by which you will elicit information from people, get new perspectives, and achieve new understandings. Tapping into people – primary sources – through interviewing is a skill honed over time.

Interviewing is a technique that is incorporated at more than one point in the information seeking process. Advertising researchers might use focus-group interviews to learn about issues they intend to examine more extensively through survey interviews later in the research process. News reporters do a preliminary set of interviews, along with background research in the news archive, in order to get themselves up to speed on the issues of the story they are covering. Public relations practitioners often interview sources such as company officials when writing news releases. Job seekers participate in interviews to discover whether the organization they are interested in is a good fit. Human resources representatives and hiring managers evaluate employees' job performance and interview potential candidates in order to fill open positions.

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1.2: Interview Types

Interviews differ according to purpose, format, and medium. The techniques used for interviews also differ depending on the goal you hope to reach through the interviewing process. Preparing to interview and be interviewed is essential for students in the communication field. 1.2.1

1.2.1 <https://open.lib.umn.edu/infostrategies/chapter/9-1-interviewing-as-a-research-skill/>

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In this textbook, we will focus on the following interview types:

- Informational interviews
- Persuasive interviews
- Employment interviews
- Appraisal interviews
- Media interviews
- Virtual interviews

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1.3: Ethical Interviewing

All interviews are opportunities to engage in ethical communication. The National Communication Association asserts that “ethical communication is fundamental to responsible thinking, decision making, and the development of relationships and communities within and across contexts, cultures, channels, and media”(2) This commission should be fulfilled by both the interviewer and interviewee in all interview settings. Open-mindedness, empathy, tolerance and effective listening are some of the skills that comprise ethical communication and are vital to interviewing success. Framing, responding and building rapport in interviews also require ethical considerations. As you explore different aspects of interviewing, consider how you can integrate ethical communication into your learning and skill development.

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1.4: Resources

- [Credo for ethical communication](#)
- [Transparency is the key to trust](#)
- [A guide to ethical interviewing practice](#)

Credo for Ethical Communication published by the National Communication Association (natcomm.org, 1999).

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

2: Planning the Interview and Developing Questions

Learning Objectives

After reading this chapter, you should be able to:

- Understand the role of questioning in interview situations.
- Apply interview preparation strategies to a variety of interview settings.
- Identify different question types and their uses.
- Understand the importance of recording interviews.

[2.1: Planning an Interview](#)

[2.2: Interview Questions](#)

[2.3: Recording the Interview](#)

[2.4: Chapter 2 Resources](#)

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2.1: Planning an Interview

Careful planning of interviews involves a number of steps and several considerations.

Interviewee's conditions:

In some cases, the interviewee stipulates some conditions for the interview which can include:

- Amount of time they will talk with you
- Interview method (face-to-face, telephone conversation or online)
- Permission (or not) to record the conversation
- Request that another person be present (their lawyer or agent).
- Request that they review the material before you may publish or use it
- The “contract” for the way the information will be used in the message (see more about this below)

Review your own material:

Looking over material gathered earlier in the information process will help you devise a strategy for using the interview to fill in questions, corroborate information, or to discover new angles to take.

- What is disputed? Can inconsistencies be explained or resolved? What is the significance of the disputed facts?
- What unexplored aspects of the subject should be developed? What is “new” that should be reflected in my questions?
- What questions are appropriate to each interviewee?
- What sensitivities and special perspectives should I be aware of in asking questions of each interviewee?
- What information in my files may need updating or confirming?
- What human-interest information can be elicited from the interviewee?

Consider interviewee “inhibitors:”

Interview preparation also involves getting ready for the social and psychological aspects of the interview. Before you draft your questions, consider the situation of the interviewee. People may have competing demands for their time. They may have painful memories of the topic you want to explore with them. They may not trust your motives in seeking the interview. This might make some interviewees unwilling to share information.

Other factors may affect the interviewee’s ability to share accurate information (as opposed to their willingness to do so). The person’s memory may have faded, they may not accurately recall the sequence of events, they may be confused by your questions. All of these inhibitors affect the way you approach your subject and the types of questions you ask.

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2.2: Interview Questions

Questions are the heart of every interview. As interviewers, we ask questions to establish rapport, persuade, confirm the accuracy of information, explore attitudes and beliefs, and clarify ambiguous information. Developing a variety of question types is a skill that all interviewers should have in their toolbox. Having assessed both the information needs and the interviewee's potential to respond, you are ready to develop an agenda of questions. These should be a comprehensive list of questions, setting forth everything you would like to know. The interviewer might ask some of these questions of a number of respondents while other questions might be designed only for a particular interviewee.

Question Types

Except in survey research interviews, open-ended questions are most effective. An example of an open-ended question is when the focus group interviewer asks, "Now that you've tried our new product, tell me what you think about it." Open-ended questions have the advantages of inviting interviewees to provide more specificity and depth in their response. In journalistic interviews, open-endedness is stressed, for it leads to spontaneity, interpretation by sources, cues for additional questions, and quotable phrases. An open-ended question in a journalistic setting might be, "What do you think about the new tax proposal?"

In the closed-ended question, the respondent must select one of a set responses provided by the interviewer. For example, most questions asked in Gallup and other polls are closed-ended: "How do you feel about the economy of the United States at this time?" "Very optimistic," "somewhat optimistic," "neutral," "somewhat pessimistic," or "very pessimistic." One advantage of closed-ended questions is that a large number of interview responses can be analyzed relatively quickly and inexpensively.

Closed-ended questioning in the journalistic context is usually problematic. Compare the closed-ended question, "Do you think the new tax proposal is good?" with the open-ended, "What do you think about the new tax proposal?" Which will elicit more information and opinion from the interviewee?

Question Order

Arranging the questions into an effective agenda is the next step. Many interviewers use a strategy of beginning with reassuringly easy questions. Some may be questions verifying that what has been learned through earlier parts of the strategy is, indeed, still accurate and up-to-date. While the opening questions may be simple, experienced interviewers avoid overly broad questions that send the interviewee off the topic or set off an avalanche of irrelevances.

Generally, experience suggests that embarrassing, touchy, or ego-threatening questions best be kept until late in the interview. By then, the context is well established and you have had a chance to develop a persona as a fair, accurate, and sensitive individual. Touchy questions always bring about the possibility that the subject will declare the interview to be at an end. In that event, at least you have the earlier portions of the conversation for the record.

Each question in the interview agenda can give rise to additional questions. Some of these are follow-ups, such as requests for more information based on the idea just stated by the source. If you are too tightly tied to your own interview agenda, you may neglect to use appropriate follow-ups.

But don't forget your original question agenda once the follow-ups begin. Rigidly adhering to the question agenda promotes one kind of completeness at the expense of expanding the topic and developing its new dimensions. Experienced interviewers learn, in time, to walk the line between the two hazards.**2.2.3**

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2.3: Recording the Interview

Think about how you will record the interview. Will written notes, a digital audio or video recording, or an e-mail transcript of questions and responses be the best way to keep track of what goes on during the interview? You have to let your interviewee know how you will record the interview. It is a breach of ethics, and in some states illegal, to record someone without their knowledge. If you use a digital recorder, always use it in conjunction with a notebook.**2.3.4**

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2.4: Chapter 2 Resources

- [A journalist speaks about asking questions](#)
- [Developing an interview guide](#)
- [Question types and ordering questions](#)

2.4.3 <https://open.lib.umn.edu/infostrateg...iew-questions/>

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

3: Informational and Persuasive Interviews

Learning Objectives

After reading this chapter, you should be able to:

- Identify characteristics of informational and persuasive interviews.
- Apply informational interview principles to everyday interactions.
- Prepare for a persuasive interview situation.

[3.1: What are Informational Interviews?](#)

[3.2: Qualities and Principles of Informational Interviews](#)

[3.3: What are Persuasive Interviews?](#)

[3.4: Persuasive Interview Examples](#)

[3.5: Chapter 3 Resources](#)

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3.1: What are Informational Interviews?

Informational interviews are, simply put, conversations. Recall some of the activities you may have engaged in during the first day of classes this semester. Your instructors may have asked you to find a partner and ask them questions in order to get to know them and “break the ice”. If you have participated in such activities, you have conducted an informational interview! Giving information and gathering information are the two main goals of this type of interview.

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3.2: Qualities and Principles of Informational Interviews

In chapter one, we discussed the principles of ethical communication and our responsibility to implement them in interview situations. Some of the qualities of an ethical and effective informational interview include:

- Empathy
- Respect
- Honesty
- Curiosity
- Patience

These qualities should characterize the way we approach informational interviews and will enable both the interviewee and interviewer to achieve their goals. Another type of interview in which these qualities are applicable is the persuasive interview.

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3.3: What are Persuasive Interviews?

Students of communication are often taught about Aristotle's Triad, which include ethos, pathos and logos. Implementing these persuasive appeals in a persuasive speech is a common practice. Utilizing persuasive appeals as well as other techniques can also be applied to persuasive interviewing. A persuasive interview involves an interviewer whose goal is to persuade an interviewee to make a choice at the end of the interview. Approaching a persuasive interview requires a thorough understanding of the elements of persuasion as well as the interviewee's past experiences with the product, position, or perspective.

Persuasive interviewers must be ethical in the way they ask questions, explain their position and allow the time and space for the interviewee to make a decision. Building rapport takes center stage in this type of interview. An effective persuasive interviewer must also anticipate objections and hesitations on the part of the interviewee. Being an ethical communicator is imperative.

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3.4: Persuasive Interview Examples

The best way to understand how a persuasive interview works is to participate in one. Consider how you might approach the following situations:

- You are an employee requesting a raise based on performance despite very few people in the organization receiving raises this year due to budget cuts.
- As the new owner of a business/franchise that lost many of its long-time customers due to poor service and mismanagement, you are now calling these customers and trying to persuade them to do business with your company.
- Mental health services on campus lack funding and many students are waiting weeks to be seen by a counselor. As a student government representative, you have been tasked with meeting with the college president and provost to seek more funding.

In these scenarios, preparation may involve developing a list of questions but it is more likely that you will need to understand your interviewees' needs, anticipate their hesitations, and strategize your persuasive approach. Above all, remember that persuasion must be done ethically and without manipulation.

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3.5: Chapter 3 Resources

- [Persuasive Strategies in Job Interviews](#)
 - [The Language of Persuasive Interviews](#)
 - [Persuasion in the Courtroom](#)
-

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

4: Employment Interviews- Interviewee

Learning Objectives

After reading this chapter, you should be able to:

- Distinguish between the different types of employment interviews.
- Prepare for an employment interview as an interviewee.
- Implement listening, responding and nonverbal communication skills as an interviewee.

One of the most popular topics in any interviewing course is the employment interview. Countless articles, websites and videos highlight job interview preparation precisely because many people are looking for a magic formula that will help land them a job. In a job search, nothing is more exciting or more intimidating than an interview. Reaching the interview stage means that you are in serious consideration for the position, and the pressure increases. In this chapter, you will learn how to prepare yourself to “ace” this process.

[4.1: Types of Interviews](#)

[4.2: Preparing for Interviews](#)

[4.3: Chapter 4 Resources](#)

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4.1: Types of Interviews

In the process of exploring occupations and landing a job, you will likely participate in a variety of interviews. They are defined by their objective:

- **Informational or networking interviews.** Informational interviewing is particularly useful in helping you explore career options. This is an interview that *you* have requested to learn about a particular job, company, or industry and how best to present yourself to potential hiring managers. An informational interview also gives you an opportunity to create a positive impression. Be sure to get referrals, leads, and recommendations for other networking contacts.
- **Screening interviews.** Generally conducted by a representative of the company's human resources department or a recruiter, a screening interview is used to determine whether you are qualified or overqualified to do the job. This initial interview is often conducted via telephone. As the name implies, the objective of this interview is to find reasons to remove, not include, people in a candidate pool. Do not consider it lightly just because someone other than the hiring manager is conducting it.
- **One-on-one interviews.** In a one-on-one interview, the interviewer asks a set of questions to learn if you have the knowledge and skills to handle the job for which you have applied. The hiring manager conducting the one-on-one interview also wants to get a sense of what it would be like working with you and how you would fit in the organization. It is also used to learn how you behaved in past situations as a predictor of how you are likely to behave in the future. Expect to be asked "Tell me about a time when..." or "Give me an example..." questions. This interview is the one a hiring decision is based on.

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4.2: Preparing for Interviews

Just as preparation is important for exams in college, preparation is key to success in interviews. Many of the principles are the same, but in an employment interview, the subject is *you*. Just as in an exam, the first step in preparation is to know your material.

- **Learn about the organization.** In almost every interview situation, you'll be asked, "What can you do for this company?" Practice your answer. Research press releases, stories in the *Wall Street Journal*, annual reports, blogs, Web sites, the news, and so on. Know the company's philosophies, goals, plans, new products, targeted customers, new executives, and major directional changes.
- **Use your network.** Do you know anyone who works for or has worked for this company or organization? Call or have lunch with them before your interview to learn more. Your competition likely won't have done their homework as well as you have. Your prospective employer will notice.
- **Review the job description.** Be prepared to explain how your background qualifies you for the job. Did you find the job posting online? Be sure to have printed a copy, and bring it with you to the interview. Some companies take weeks to start calling people in for interviews, and by then the job description may have been removed from the site where you saw it.
- **Review your résumé.** Think of examples that describe or illustrate your accomplishments. You will be asked about items on your résumé, and you need to be able to support them and go into more detail.(5)

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4.3: Chapter 4 Resources

- [Common Interview Questions](#)
- [Why Should We Hire You?](#)
- [Mastering the Art of the Group Interview](#)

(5) <https://2012books.lardbucket.org/books/success.html>

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

5: Employment Interviews- Interviewer

Learning Objectives

After reading this chapter, you should be able to:

- Explain the various types of interviews and interview questions.
- Discuss interview methods and potential mistakes in interviewing candidates.
- Explain the interview process.

[5.1: Approaching the Interview as an Interviewer](#)

[5.2: Types of Interviews](#)

[5.3: Interview Questions](#)

[5.4: Illegal Interview Questions](#)

[5.5: Chapter 5 Resources](#)

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5.1: Approaching the Interview as an Interviewer

Interviewing people costs money. As a result, after candidates are selected, good use of time is critical to making sure the interview process allows for selection of the right candidate. In an unstructured interview, questions are changed to match the specific applicant; for example, questions about the candidate's background in relation to their résumé might be used. In a structured interview, there is a set of standardized questions based on the job analysis, not on individual candidates' résumés.

While a structured interview might seem the best option to find out about a particular candidate, the bigger concern is that the interview revolves around the specific job for which the candidate is interviewing. In a structured interview, the expected or desired answers are determined ahead of time, which allows the interviewer to rate responses as the candidate provides answers. This allows for a fair interview process, according to the US Office of Personnel Management. "Structured Interviews: A Practical Guide"(6). For purposes of this section, we will assume that all interviews you perform will be structured, unless otherwise noted.

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5.2: Types of Interviews

Interview processes can be time-consuming, so it makes sense to choose the right type of interview(s) for the individual job. Some jobs, for example, may necessitate only one interview, while another may necessitate a virtual interview and at least one or two traditional interviews. Here are different types of interviews:

(6) US Office of Personnel Management, September 2008, accessed January 25, 2011, <https://apps.opm.gov/ADT/ContentFiles/SIGuide09.08.08.pdf>

1. **Traditional interview.** This type of interview normally takes place in the office. It consists of the interviewer and the candidate, and a series of questions are asked and answered.
2. **Panel interview.** A panel interview occurs when several people are interviewing one candidate at the same time. While this type of interview can be nerve racking for the candidate, it can also be a more effective use of time. Consider some companies who require three to four people to interview candidates for a job. It would be unrealistic to ask the candidate to come in for three or four interviews, so it makes sense for them to be interviewed by everyone at once.
3. **Information interview.** Informational interviews are usually used when there is no specific job opening, but the candidate is exploring possibilities in a given career field. The advantage to conducting these types of interviews is the ability to find great people ahead of a job opening.
4. **Group interview.** In a group interview, two or more candidates interview at the same time. This type of interview can be an excellent source of information if you need to know how they may relate to other people in their job.
5. **Virtual interviews.** Video interviews are the same as traditional interviews, except that video technology is used. This can be cost saving if one or more of your candidates are from out of town and virtual interviews have become commonplace during the pandemic. A virtual interview may not feel the same as a traditional interview, but the same information can be gathered about the candidate. You'll learn more about preparing for these interviews in chapter ten.
6. **Nondirective interview** (sometimes called an unstructured interview). In a nondirective interview, the candidate essentially leads the discussion. Some very general questions that are planned ahead of time may be asked, but the candidate spends more time talking than the interviewer. The questions may be more open-ended; for example, instead of asking, "Do you like working with customers?" you may ask, "What did you like best about your last job?" The advantage of this type of interview is that it can give candidates a good chance to show their abilities; however, the downside is that it may be hard to compare potential candidates, since questions are not set in advance. It relies on more of a "gut feeling" approach.

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5.3: Interview Questions

Most interviews consist of many types of questions, but they usually lean toward situational interviews or behavior description interviews. A situational interview is one in which the candidate is given a sample situation and is asked how he or she might deal with the situation. In a behavior description interview, the candidate is asked questions about what he or she actually did in a variety of given situations.

The assumption in this type of interview is that someone's past experience or actions are an indicator of future behavior. These types of questions, as opposed to the old "tell me about yourself" questions, tend to assist the interviewer in knowing how a person would handle or has handled situations. These interview styles also use a structured method and provide a better basis for decision making. Examples of situational interview questions might include the following:

1. If you saw someone stealing from the company, what would you do?
2. One of your employees is performing poorly, but you know he has some personal home issues he is dealing with. How would you handle complaints from his colleagues about lack of performance?
3. A coworker has told you she called in sick three days last week because she actually decided to take a vacation. What would you do?
4. You are rolling out a new sales plan on Tuesday, which is really important to ensure success in your organization. When you present it, the team is lukewarm on the plan. What would you do?
5. You disagree with your supervisor on her handling of a situation. What would you do?

Examples of behavior description interview questions might include the following:

1. Tell me about a time you had to make a hard decision. How did you handle this process?
2. Give an example of how you handled an angry customer.
3. Do you show leadership in your current or past job? What would be an example of a situation in which you did this?
4. What accomplishments have given you the most pride and why?
5. What plans have you made to achieve your career goals?

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5.4: Illegal Interview Questions

As you already know, there are many types of interview questions that would be considered illegal. Here are some examples:

1. **National origin.** You cannot ask seemingly innocent questions such as “That’s a beautiful name, where is your family from?” This could indicate national origin, which could result in bias. You also cannot ask questions about citizenship, except by asking if a candidate is legally allowed to work in the United States. Questions about the first language of the candidate shouldn’t be asked, either. However, asking “Do you have any language abilities that would be helpful in this job?” or “Are you authorized to work in the United States?” would be acceptable.
2. **Age.** You cannot ask someone how old they are, and it is best to avoid questions that might indicate age, such as “When did you graduate from high school?” However, asking “Are you over 18?” is acceptable.
3. **Marital status.** You can’t ask direct questions about marital status or ages of children. An alternative may be to ask, “Do you have any restrictions on your ability to travel, since this job requires 50 percent travel?”
4. **Religion.** It’s illegal to ask candidates about their religious affiliation or to ask questions that may indicate a religion-affiliated school or university.
5. **Disabilities.** You may not directly ask if the person has disabilities or recent illnesses. You can ask if the candidate is able to perform the functions of the job with or without reasonable accommodations.
6. **Criminal record.** While it is fine to perform a criminal record check, asking a candidate if they have ever been arrested is not appropriate; however, questions about convictions and guilty pleadings are acceptable.
7. **Personal questions.** Avoid asking personal questions, such as questions about social organizations or clubs, unless they relate to the job.

Besides these questions, any specific questions about weight, height, gender, and arrest record (as opposed to allowable questions about criminal convictions) should be avoided.(7)

5.4: Illegal Interview Questions is shared under a [not declared](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

5.5: Chapter 5 Resources

- [How to Conduct Interviews](#)
- [The Ten Best Interview Questions to Reveal Behavioral Quirks](#)
- [How to Recruit and Hire the Best Job Candidates](#)

(7) <https://courses.lumenlearning.com/cerritos-hrmanagement/chapter/5-3-interviewing/>

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

6: Appraisal Interviews

Learning Objectives

after reading this chapter, you should be able to:

- Understand the components of an appraisal interview.
- Communicate skillfully in appraisal interviews, as both interviewer and interviewee

Appraisal interviews are an integral part of any organization and can provide both the employer and the employee with valuable information about job performance, organizational challenges and successes, as well as company culture. Just like any other interview, the appraisal interview should be a dialogue where an employee can ask and respond to questions and the employer can do the same.

[6.1: Best Practices in Performance Appraisals](#)

[6.2: Chapter 6 Resources](#)

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6.1: Best Practices in Performance Appraisals

A performance review process could be intricately detailed and organized, but if the meeting with the employee doesn't go well, the overall strategic objective of performance reviews may not be met. In Norman R. F. Maier's famous book *The Appraisal Interview*, he addressed three types of appraisal interview styles. The first is the tell and sell interview. In this type of interview, the manager does most of the talking and passes his or her view to the employee. In the tell and listen type of interview, the manager communicates feedback and then addresses the employee's thoughts about the interview. In the problem-solving interview, the employee and the manager discuss the things that are going well and those that are not going well, which can make for a more productive discussion. To provide the best feedback to the employee, consider the following:

1. **Be direct and specific.** Use examples to show where the employee has room for improvement and where the employee exceeds expectations, such as, "The expectation is zero accidents, and you have not had any accidents this year."
2. **Do not be personal;** always compare the performance to the standard. For example, instead of saying, "You are too slow on the production line," say, the "expectations are ten units per hour, and currently you are at eight units."
3. **Remember, it is a development opportunity.** As a result, encourage the employee to talk. Understand what the employee feels he does well and what he thinks he needs to improve.
4. **Thank the employee and avoid criticism.** Instead of the interview being a list of things the employee doesn't do well (which may give the feeling of criticizing), thank the employee for what the employee does well, and work on action plans together to fix anything the employee isn't doing well. Think of it as a team effort to get the performance to the standard it needs to be.

The result of a completed performance evaluation usually means there are a variety of ramifications that can occur after evaluating employee performance:

1. The employee now has written, documented feedback on his or her performance.
2. The organization has documented information on low performance, in case the employee needs to be dismissed.
3. The employee has performed well and is eligible for a raise.
4. The employee has performed well and could be promoted.
5. Performance is not up to expectations, so an improvement plan should be put into place.
6. The employee hasn't done well, improvement plans have not worked (the employee has been warned before), and the employee should be dismissed.

In each of these cases, planning in advance of the performance appraisal interview is important, so all information is available to communicate to the employee. Consider Robin, an employee at Blewett Gravel who was told she was doing an excellent job. Robin was happy with the performance appraisal and when asked about promotion opportunities, the manager said none was available. This can devalue a positive review and impact employee motivation. The point, of course, is to use performance evaluations as a development tool, which will positively impact employee motivation. (8)

(8) <https://courses.lumenlearning.com/cerritos-hrmanagement/chapter/11-3-completing-and-conducting-the-appraisal/>

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6.2: Chapter 6 Resources

- [What Not to Do in an Appraisal Interview](#)
 - [Preparing for a Performance Evaluation](#)
 - [Performance Review Tips](#)
-

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

7: Media Interviews

Learning Objectives

After reading this chapter, you should be able to:

- Discuss the purpose of media interviews.
- Understand how to prepare for media interviews.

[7.1: Defining Media Interviews](#)

[7.2: Media Interview Preparation](#)

[7.3: Chapter 7 Resources](#)

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7.1: Defining Media Interviews

At some point in your career it's likely that you will be interviewed by a representative of the media. It may be a camera and microphone in your face as you leave a building, or a scheduled interview where you have an opportunity to prepare. A press interview is both a challenge and an opportunity. Like a speech, it may make you nervous, but you have the advantage of being the center of attention and having the opportunity to have your say. This chapter addresses the basics for preparing and participating in a press interview.

A **media interview** is a discussion involving questions and answers for the purpose of broadcast. It is distinct from an informational interview (McLean, S., 2005), where you might be asked questions to learn background on a story, but you will still need to observe the three hallmark rules of interviews:

1. Anything you say can and often will be used against you.
2. Never say anything you would not feel comfortable hearing quoted out of context on the evening news.
3. Be prepared for the unexpected as well as the expected.

At first, those rules may sound extreme, but let's examine them in the context of today's media realities. In a press interview setting you will be recorded in some fashion, whether audio, video, or handwritten notes on a reporter's notepad. With all the probability for errors and misinterpretation, you want your words and gestures to project the best possible image to the press. There was a time when news programs didn't have to justify themselves with advertising dollars, but today all news is news entertainment and has to pay its own way. That means your interview will be used to attract viewers.

You also have to consider the possibility that the person interviewing you is not a trained professional journalist, but rather an aspiring actor or writer who happened to land a job with the media. From their perspective, your quote in an audio, video, or print content package is dinner. It may also serve the public good, and inform, or highlight an important cause, but news has a bottom line just like business.

Because of these factors, you need to be proactive in seeing the press interview as part of the overall spectacle that is media, devoted to revenue. The six-second quote that is taken from the interview may not represent the tone, range, or even substance of your comments, but it will have been chosen to grab attention. It will also go viral if it catches on. Your interviewer may ask you a question that is off-the-wall, inappropriate, outside the scope of the interview, or unusual just to catch you off guard and get that attention-worthy quote. Independent journalism with a nonprofit, inform-the-public orientation still exists in some forms, but even those media outlets have to support themselves with an audience. So consider your role in the interview: to provide information and represent your business or organization with honor and respect. In sports, business, and press interviews, a good defense is required.

That said, a press interview is a positive opportunity, whether it is planned in advance or catches you off guard in public. You are the focus of the interview, and many people believe that if you are on television, for example, that you have something to say, that you have special insight, or that you are different from the viewing audience. That can give you an edge of credibility that can serve your business or company as you share your knowledge and experience.

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7.2: Media Interview Preparation

When asked to give an interview, before you agree, learn as much as you can about the topic, the timing, the format, and the background. Table 1: “Interview Preparation Factors” summarizes how to approach these factors.

Table 1: Interview Preparation Factors

Topic	What will be the range or scope of the interview? How can you prepare yourself so you are better able to address specific questions? Ask for the list of questions in advance, and anticipate that you will be asked questions that are not listed. Prepare for the unexpected and you won't be caught off guard.
Time	What's the time frame or limit? A 15-minute interview may not require as much depth as one that lasts an hour or more.
Format	How will you be interviewed? Will it be through audio or video, over the Internet, over the telephone, or in person?
Background	What's the backstory of the interview? Is there a specific issue or incident? Is there a known agenda? Why is the interview now and not earlier or not at all? Why is it important?

These four areas will serve you well as you begin to define the range and content of the interview for yourself. You will also need to pay attention to the setting and scene, how you want to present yourself (attire), and how well you answer anticipated questions. Mock interviews with colleagues can help, and a comprehensive knowledge of your talking points is essential.

You want to be well rested, if at all possible, on the day of the interview. With a clear mind you will be agile and responsive, and you will be able to present yourself well. You'll be calm in the knowledge of your preparation, and not be thrown if an unexpected question comes your way. You'll be ready on time, understanding that most journalists have to package the story as quickly as possible, demonstrating respect for the interviewer. You'll also know that it is not just about what you say but how you say it. Audiences respond to emotional cues, and you want to project an image of credibility and integrity. You'll anticipate the question-and-answer pattern and limit your responses to ones that are clear and concise. You'll have visual aids ready if needed to make a point.

Naturally, however, you may not have the luxury of time to prepare. Press interviews are often requested at the last minute, and you may not be the first person this reporter asked for an interview that day. They have a story in mind, and they are looking for you to be part of that story. If the opportunity to be interviewed arises on the spur of the moment, you will need to make a quick judgment on whether to agree or decline.

Your decision will rest on a multitude of factors, such as how much you know about the topic, whether someone else in your organization is better qualified to answer, whether your employer would appreciate your agreeing to speak to the media, and so on. If something newsworthy occurs at your workplace, start thinking about how you would make this decision before you are put on the spot. Finally, if the topic of the media inquiry is not time urgent, remember that you can always ask to postpone the interview to allow time to prepare.(9)

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7.3: Chapter 7 Resources

- [Investigative Interviewing](#)
- [How to conduct a media interview](#)

(9) https://pressbooks-dev.oer.hawaii.edu/cmchang/chapter/15-5-media-interviews/#mclean-ch15_s05_t01

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

8: Interviewing Skills- Listening

Learning Objectives

After reading this chapter, you should be able to:

- Understand the components of the listening process.
- Distinguish between passive and active listening.
- Demonstrate active listening skills in an interview setting.

[8.1: The Importance of Listening Well](#)

[8.2: Active Listening in Interview Settings](#)

[8.3: Chapter 8 Resources](#)

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8.1: The Importance of Listening Well

Being a good communicator involves not only being good at speaking. Listening is an essential part of communication and is often the weakest link in the communication process. People usually love to be heard but are often not as excited about listening. Active listening is being engaged as a listener, not just hearing the words.

Are you a good listener? Most of us like to think we are, but when we really think about it, we recognize that we are often only half-listening. We're distracted, thinking about other things, or formulating what we are going to say in reaction to what we are hearing before the speaker has even finished. Effective listening is one of the most important learning tools you can have in college or university. And it is a skill that will benefit you on the job and help your relationships with others. Listening is nothing more than purposefully focusing on what a speaker is saying with the objective of understanding.

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8.2: Active Listening in Interview Settings

This definition is straightforward, but there are some important concepts that deserve a closer look. “Purposefully focusing” implies that you are actively processing what the speaker is saying, not just letting the sounds of their voice register in your senses. “With the objective of understanding” means that you will learn enough about what the speaker is saying to be able to form your own thoughts about the speaker’s message. Listening is an active process, as opposed to hearing, which is passive.

Being an active listener takes concentration and work. The principles of active listening are not hard to understand, but they are hard to implement and require practice to use them effectively.

Listening is a significant part of the interview process. However, active listening is even more important and it is vital to professional achievement. “Recruiters rank listening at the top of employers’ wish lists. People with good listening skills are more likely than others to be hired and promoted. Having read the above information on listening, we all need to make sure we are focused and concentrating on doing it well. Active listening is just not the famous nod of the head and or giving good eye contact. “Active listening is giving your undivided attention and acknowledging the message that is being delivered.” (10)

Even if the listener doesn’t agree with the speaker, it is important to acknowledge that the speaker has a right to their point of view, their ideas and their feelings. Be respectful of others’ opinions, and keep in mind that cultural differences can impact beliefs, values, and communication styles. Signs of distraction include looking away, humming, doodling, checking your phone, texting, or surfing the web. This communicates that you are uninterested in what the speaker is saying.(11)

Here are some things you can do to let the interviewers know you are actively listening:

- Paraphrase questions before responding.
- Communicate your appreciation for the question and repeat the question.
- Don’t interrupt when questions are being asked or comments are being stated.
- Lean forward when others are speaking and tilt your ear slightly towards the speaker.

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8.3: Chapter 8 Resources

- [TED Talk: Five Ways to Listen Better](#)
- [Listening for Interview Success](#)
- [Active Listening Skills](#)

(10) [thepalmergroup.com](#)

(11) <https://opentextbc.ca/studentsuccess/chapter/active-listening/> “Communication Skills” in the [Education and Career Planning Open Course](#) by Mary Shier. [CC BY](#); “[Are you really listening](#)” in *University Success* by N. Mahoney, B. Klassen, and M. D'Eon. Adapted by Mary Shier. [CC BY-NC-SA](#).

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

9: Interviewing Skills- Avoiding Filler Words

Learning Objectives

After reading this chapter, you should be able to:

- Identify some of the most common filler words.
- Develop techniques for avoiding filler words in interviews.

[9.1: What are filler words and why do we use them?](#)

[9.2: How can we reduce our use of filler words?](#)

[9.3: Chapter 9 Resources](#)

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9.1: What are filler words and why do we use them?

Do these look familiar: um, ah, like, you know, and yeah, er, okay, uh? They should. Most of us currently use them or have used them before. Unfortunately, they add no value to your communication. In fact, you can remove these from your communication repertoire and still speak in complete sentences. There are names for these: filler words, filler phrases, and filler sounds.

"A filler is an apparently meaningless word, phrase, or sound that marks a pause or hesitation in speech. Also known as a pause filler or hesitation form. Some of the common **filler words** in English are um, uh, er, ah, like, okay, right, and you know".(12)

"Recently I worked with a client who was a Solutions Architect. He had good experience and was getting interviews, and he answered interview questions well. He sounded like someone any company would want to hire, except for one thing – when he spoke he said “um” constantly. Although his other interview skills were good, the “um’s” made him sound unprofessional.” (13)

Some people use fillers when they are having anxiety, when thinking about what they want to say next, when they don’t know their topic well, or because it’s a habit. Regardless of the reason, you will be a better communicator when you eliminate or decrease your usage of fillers, because fillers may be distracting to the person or audience you’re speaking to. Some may even view you as less intelligent if you use fillers.

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9.2: How can we reduce our use of filler words?

When considering your use of filler words, you might assume: “Eliminating fillers totally is very difficult.” and even think: “I don’t even realize I’m using fillers.” We should all say, “I want to decrease or totally eliminate fillers from my vocabulary.” It can be done with dedication and lots of practice. You must be patient with yourself when realizing you are using fillers in general or using fillers way too much. Using a filler or two may go undetected. However, using too many can negatively impact your personal and professional relationships.

Record a conversation and count the use of unnecessary pauses and filler words in relation to the other words in the speech. See if you can reduce the ratio over time. Remember that as you become more confident and familiar with speaking it will be easier to reduce the frequency of many of the unnecessary filler words and pauses.(14)

Be patient with yourself and practice.

(12) Nordquist, R. *Definitions and Examples of Filler Words*. July 3, 2019. Retrieved from: www.thoughtco.com

(13) Scupi, J. *Interview Advice*. Retrieved on January 7, 2022 from www.interviewgenie.com

9.2: How can we reduce our use of filler words? is shared under a [not declared](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

9.3: Chapter 9 Resources

- [How to Stop Saying “Um” and Other Filler Words](#)
- [Avoid Filler Words](#)
- [Reducing filler words in job interviews](#)

(14) <https://lumen.instructure.com/courses/218897/pages/linkedtext54275>. The content of this page is licensed under a [Creative Commons Attribution Share-Alike License](#)

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

10: Interviewing Skills- Nonverbal Communication

Learning Objectives

After reading this chapter, you should be able to:

- Demonstrate the importance of nonverbal communication and describe its role in the communication process.
- Understand and explain the principles of nonverbal communication.

[10.1: Defining Nonverbal Communication](#)

[10.2: How Nonverbal Cues Communicate Emotions and Identity](#)

[10.3: Chapter 10 Resources](#)

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10.1: Defining Nonverbal Communication

Nonverbal communication refers to gestures, facial expressions, tone of voice, eye contact (or lack thereof), body language, posture, and other ways people can communicate without using language.(15)

What you say is a vital part of any communication, but what you don't say can be even more important. Research also shows that 55 percent of in-person communication comes from non-verbal cues, such as facial expressions, body stance, and smell. According to one study, only 7 percent of a receiver's comprehension of a message is based on the sender's actual words; 38 percent is based on paralanguage (the tone, pace, and volume of speech), and 55 percent is based on non-verbal cues such as body language (Mehrabian, 1981).(16)

Why is non-verbal communication important?

- Basically, it is one of the key aspects of communication (and especially important in a high-context culture). It has multiple functions:
 - Used to **repeat** the verbal message (e.g. point in a direction while stating directions).
 - Often used to **accent** a verbal message. (e.g. verbal tone indicates the actual meaning of the specific words).
 - Often **complement** the verbal message but also may contradict. E.g.: a nod reinforces a positive message (among Americans); a “wink” may contradict a stated positive message.
 - **Regulate** interactions (non-verbal cues convey when the other person should speak or not speak).
 - May **substitute** for the verbal message (especially if it is blocked by noise, interruption, etc) — i.e. gestures (finger to lips to indicate need for quiet), facial expressions (Tidwell, 2023).

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10.2: How Nonverbal Cues Communicate Emotions and Identity

Research shows that non-verbal cues can also affect whether you get a job offer. Judges examining videotapes of actual applicants were able to assess the social skills of job candidates with the sound turned off. They watched the rate of gesturing, time spent talking, and formality of dress to determine which candidates would be the most successful socially on the job (Gifford, Ng, and Wilkinson, 1985).

For this reason, it is important to consider how we appear in the professional environment as well as what we say. Our facial muscles convey our emotions. We can send a silent message without saying a word. A change in facial expression can change our emotional state. Before an interview, for example, if we focus on feeling confident, our face will convey that confidence to an interviewer. Adopting a smile (even if we are feeling stressed) can reduce the body's stress levels.(17)

Your nonverbal communication during an interview can either complement your character and skills or diminish them. Exhibiting positive nonverbal communication may help persuade interviewer(s) that you are enthusiastic about the opportunity and skilled enough to do the job. Nonverbal cues such as eye contact, tone, attention to proxemics, facial expressions, etc. will allow the interviewer to see if you have the ability to effectively work with current employees, clients, internal and external stakeholders.

All of these nonverbal communication assets may persuade the interviewer(s) that you not only have the necessary verbal skills, but also the nonverbal skills to do the job well and be able to connect with those who you will work with every day. Let's explore a few nonverbal cues and how they can be used to enhance professionalism:

- **Kinesics** Generally speaking, simplicity, directness, and warmth convey sincerity, and sincerity is key to effective communication. A firm handshake given with a warm, dry hand is a great way to establish trust. A weak, clammy handshake conveys a lack of trustworthiness. Gnawing one's lip conveys uncertainty. A direct smile conveys confidence. All of this is true across North America. However, in other cultures the same firm handshake may be considered aggressive and untrustworthy. It helps to be mindful of cultural context when interpreting or using body language.
- **Eye Contact**
In business, the style and duration of eye contact people consider appropriate varies greatly across cultures. In the United States, looking someone in the eye (for about a second) is considered a sign of trustworthiness.
- **Facial Expressions**
The human face can produce thousands of different expressions. Experts have decoded these expressions as corresponding to hundreds of different emotional states (Ekman, Friesen, and Hager, 2008). Our faces convey basic information to the outside world. Happiness is associated with an upturned mouth and slightly closed eyes; fear, with an open mouth and wide-eyed stare. Flitting ("shifty") eyes and pursed lips convey a lack of trustworthiness. The effect facial expressions have on conversation is instantaneous. Our brains may register them as "a feeling" about someone's character.

Posture

The position of our body relative to a chair or another person is another powerful silent messenger that conveys interest, aloofness, professionalism—or lack thereof. Head up, back straight (but not rigid) implies an upright character. In interview situations, experts advise mirroring an interviewer's tendency to lean in and settle back in her seat. The subtle repetition of the other person's posture conveys that we are listening and responding

(15) Doyle, Allison. *Nonverbal Communication Skills List and Examples*. September 2020. Retrieved on January 4, 2022

from <https://www.thebalancecareers.com>

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10.3: Chapter 10 Resources

- [12 Examples of Nonverbal Communication](#)
 - [Nonverbal Job Interview Mistakes to Avoid](#)
 - [Piercings, Hairstyles and Tattoos as Nonverbal Cues](#)
-

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

11: Interviewing Skills- Mastering Virtual Interviews

Learning Objectives

After reading this chapter, you should be able to:

- Identify some of the reasons for the prevalence of virtual interviewing.
- Understand the unique characteristics of virtual interviews.
- Incorporate a variety of communication skills in your next virtual interview.

[11.1: Virtual Interviews- the New Normal?](#)

[11.2: Ten Tips for Virtual Interviewing Success](#)

[11.3: Chapter 11 Resources](#)

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11.1: Virtual Interviews- the New Normal?

In chapter five, we identified a variety of interview types you may experience when seeking employment. A virtual interview is one of them. Virtual interviews are conducted via videoconferencing platforms such as Zoom, Microsoft Teams or FaceTime. As early as 2011, hiring managers began to utilize videoconferencing to conduct interviews with candidates who did not reside locally, saving organizations and candidates time and money.(18)

Today, virtual interviews are almost as ubiquitous as face-to-face interviews. When the COVID-19 pandemic emerged in 2019, virtual meetings and interviews became a promising practice for staying connected to colleagues and hiring employees. Organizations had to quickly pivot and increase the use of virtual tools in order to keep their current and potential employees and clients safe.

Virtual interviews can also be more convenient for employers and interviewees by saving money and travel time, expanding the candidate pool (no geographical restrictions), and minimizing scheduling conflicts. While there are drawbacks to virtual interviewing, it is now considered the safest and fastest way to conduct business in the era of COVID-19.(19) Embracing virtual interviewing can help enhance and ensure that the appropriate talent is hired and the well-being and safety needs of all parties involved are taken into consideration.

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11.2: Ten Tips for Virtual Interviewing Success

Understanding the importance of virtual interviewing and being able to make a positive first impression during a virtual interview is a skill set that can increase your chances of successfully landing a job in an environment that increasingly requires mediated communication skills.

Consider the following ten tips for success as you prepare for your next virtual interview:

1. Prepare notes in advance. However, refer to them sparingly.
2. Show up/sign on a few minutes early and think about your virtual background.
3. Dress to impress (even though it's virtual).
4. Test your set-up: camera glare, eye level toward camera, too far-too close to camera, audio, etc.
5. If you believe hand gestures enhance your communication, be sure to practice slightly elevating hand/arms movements, so they can be seen.
6. Use facial expressions to show when you are really engaged.
7. Incorporate a virtual handshake.
8. Put a disclaimer out that you may feel a little awkward not being in person and that you will do your best to minimize any barriers. Also, feel comfortable communicating barriers on their end as well.
9. Set aside time for practice sessions. Tape record at least 2-4 practice sessions, observe sessions, and do some self-talk/self-reflection. Also, feel free to share practice session(s) with trustworthy friends/family and ask them to give constructive feedback.
- While practicing, pay close attention to how you sound: too fast/slow, too soft/loud, etc.
- Also check for good posture: back as straight as possible, face towards camera, shoulders back, etc.
10. Minimize interruptions: put pets in a safe place so you/interviewers won't see/hear them during the interview, ask family/friends to support you by not being seen/heard during the interview, shut doors and windows so that outside/external noise level is decreased.

This is not an exhaustive list but by implementing these tips, you will be better positioned to succeed in a virtual interview.

(18) Zielinski, D. The Virtual Interview. July 1, 2012. Retrieved from: <https://www.shrm.org/hr-today/news/hr-magazine/pages/0712tech.aspx>

(19) Miller, B. Pros and Cons of Virtual Interviews. August 26, 2021. Retrieved from <https://hrdailyadvisor.blr.com/>

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11.3: Chapter 11 Resources

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 - [Skype Job Interview Tips](#)
 - [Online Interviewing Tips](#)
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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

12: Conclusion- Wrapping it Up and Looking Ahead

Learning Objectives

After reading this chapter, you should be able to:

- Engage in reflection activities in order to improve skills in future interviews.
- Review interview types and approaches covered in earlier chapters.
- Apply nonverbal and verbal communication skills learned in your next interview.

[12.1: Reflecting- What Does a Successful Interview Look Like?](#)

[12.2: Wrapping it Up and Looking Ahead](#)

[12.3: Chapter 12 Resources](#)

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12.1: Reflecting- What Does a Successful Interview Look Like?

As you review what you have learned in this course and textbook, one of the best ways to evaluate your knowledge and skills is to reflect upon your interview experiences. Recording an interview (with permission from the other party) can provide you with the opportunity to observe yourself in an interview setting. Here are some questions you may want to ask yourself as you observe your performance:

1. Did I open and close the interview in a professional manner?
2. Did I make eye contact and speak clearly?
3. Did I listen effectively?
4. Were my questions/responses clear?
5. How did my nonverbal cues affect the interview?
6. What did I do well in the interview? What can I improve?
7. Did I accomplish my interview goals?

By asking these questions (or a variation of them) after each interview you participate in, you will give yourself more opportunities for growth and improvement as an interviewer and interviewee.

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12.2: Wrapping it Up and Looking Ahead

In this textbook, we have explored a variety of interview types, components and skills. You have learned how to develop questions, participate in persuasive and informational interviews as well as employment and appraisal interviews. We have discussed listening, nonverbal cues and ways to minimize filler words in interview settings. Finally, we have examined the prevalence of virtual interviews and provided techniques for mastering them.

Whether you are interviewing a celebrity, being interviewed for a job, or simply gathering information about a topic or person, all interviewing should be conducted with empathy, tolerance and consideration of others. It is often more important to maintain a personal or professional relationship and conduct ourselves in a flexible manner than to achieve an interview goal at any cost.

It is our intention that this textbook be one more tool in your interviewing toolbox. Interviewing is an art that requires ongoing exploration and practice. We hope you will continue your learning by practicing new skills and perfecting existing ones. Let your curiosity be your guide!

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12.3: Chapter 12 Resources

- [Professors Miller and Savoy Share Tips for Interviewing Success](#)
 - [Evaluating Your Interview Performance](#)
 - [Evaluating Your Performance to Improve Interview Skills](#)
 - [Write a Reflection About Your Interview](#)
-

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Glossary

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